



First tourist in space

In 2001, Denis Tito became the world's first space tourist to enjoy an eight-day holiday aboard the International Space Station. His ticket cost him \$20 million

Laika's sacrifice

Laika, a Soviet dog, became the first animal to orbit the Earth, aboard the spacecraft Sputnik 2. Sadly, Laika died in space, as it couldn't be brought back to earth

Feature

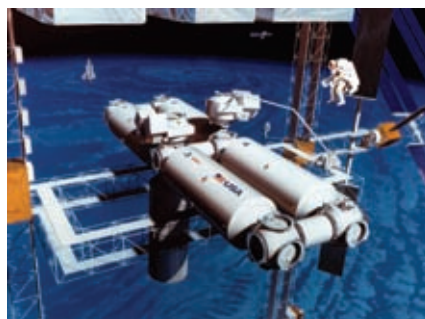
solution soon, some theories suggest that we may be on the verge of a rather serious series of accidents – one big collision in orbit could cause a chain reaction of sorts, sending debris everywhere, taking out all our satellites and knocking us back to the days of radio!

The good news is that the those responsible for most of the junk to begin with, are finally waking up to the dangers.

NASA has started the Orbital Debris Program, which can't really run a clean-up job just yet, but currently tracks the size and speed of the debris in orbit around Earth. At least if they know what's out there they can try and avoid it.

Cleaning up

There are a lot of ideas on how we could do a cosmic cleanup, but not many are doable just yet. For instance, Jim Holloper, the man who helped design rockets during the 1980s, has suggested that aging rockets loaded with water



The International Space Station

could be used to spray orbiting junk and knock them towards the atmosphere to burn up. Other ideas include junk-zapping lasers that would put Hollywood sfx to shame – after all, if lasers can take out missiles, they can also incinerate junk?

Some suggestions just border on crazy, like deploying large nets magnets to snag the junk. Actually, even blasting big shards of junk would only lead to smaller more dangerous particles – more dangerous because

they become almost impossible to track the smaller they get. Suggestions get weirder still – like making a gigantic vacuum cleaner! What exactly would a vacuum cleaner suck in, when space is vacuum to begin with?

The bigger pieces of junk are a little easier to solve for. Ideas include sending-up special space vehicles that can rendezvous with the largest of the junk and attach a propulsion system to send them crashing back to Earth.

The best way forward is in fact to stop polluting space to begin with. Whether governments or private organizations, we need to make it mandatory to carry back everything a mission carries into space. We don't know about you, but we'd very much like to have the option of visiting space in our lifetime made available to us. This won't happen, unless we make it a point to let the powers that be know how much we dislike the great garbage dump in the sky. **d**



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